

KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 7: *Measures to Relieve Tension*¹

In the first six chapters of *Neurosis and Human Growth*, we learned about the dream house that is created by our neurotic imagination and built on the foundation of our search for a phantom glory. As neurotics, we believe that achieving this false glory will fulfill our craving for survival, security, self-confidence, and fulfillment. The foundation of our dream house is, however, as unstable as sand, but we hope that the framework of our personal law—our shoulds, claims, and taboos—will be strong enough to overcome that little weakness. This personal law unconsciously shapes our values and drives our judgments, and we waste precious energy slaving to comply with these neurotic standards of glory. But since the world and even our own choices regularly fall short of those standards, we live in the constant dread of self-hate with its self-sabotage, self-condemnation, and self-torment.

We feel proud of our little house, even though its foundation is built on sand and its framework constructed out of the flimsy judgments of our compulsive shoulds and claims. Our pride is invested in who we imagine ourselves to be and what we imagine we can do, but that pride is as vulnerable as wallpaper glued over cardboard. How easily our pride is hurt! Our paper shreds with the slightest insult or misunderstanding, and we find ourselves constantly running around with a glue gun and paint pot trying to keep up appearances. We paste together our shredding self-image by blaming others and life's adversities, punishing others or ourselves, and escaping into addictive behaviors. More and more of our energy goes into maintaining appearances, not just to fool others but to deceive ourselves. The more vulnerable the house, the greater the need for the glue gun and paint. That creates a lot of tension. Deep down we know that our house is built on sand and that the slightest spark will engulf the whole thing in flames. We are chronically anxious.

As neurotics, we fear many things, but what we fear most is losing control. Fear drives us to take responsibility for everyone and everything—except ourselves. We create our own soap operas or watch the soap opera lives of others, distracting ourselves with drama rather than dealing with our fears. We really have very little vision for changing ourselves, which is why most religions and philosophies claim that no one really changes. That is not, however, the message of Christianity. Perhaps one of the most shocking assertions of the Bible is that you can change. By examining and tackling your neurosis, you can repent. You can turn around. You can go home.²

Jesus invites you to turn around and come home. He wants to help you find the person you were designed to be before the world, your culture, your upbringing, and your fear kidnapped you and carried you into a far country of anxiety and lost potential. The ransom has been paid for you, and if you are a Christian, you have a built-in guide—the Holy Spirit, who can lead you back to where you belong.

In First John we are taught that only God's love working through us can cast out fear.³ Fear reveals itself in so many ways. We can feel rage, disgust, grief, shame, hate, resentment, competition, or we might become numb, but the underlying emotion is fear. Fear can be our friend, however. It is the flag that tells

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

² Luke 15:14–24.

³ 1 John 4:18.

us that we are not accessing the love of God. That is a very helpful realization. Fear identifies the areas of our house that are built on sand, and once we have identified those areas, we can start rebuilding on the solid rock of God's love.